

See also: *Entr'acte* (1924) ■ *Un Chien Andalou* (1929, pp.330–31) ■ *À propos de Nice* (1930) ■ *L'Age d'Or* (1930) ■ *Jean Taris*, *Swimming Champion* (1931) ■ *L'Atalante* (1934) ■ *The 400 Blows* (1959, pp.150–55) ■ *If...* (1968)



edges can be attributed to Vigo's inexperience as a director, but there are many deliberately eccentric flourishes—such as a cartoon sketch that suddenly comes to life.

Diving straight in

The beginning of the movie dispenses with any sense of buildup—a simple title card reads, “After the holidays, back to school.” A boy, Causset (Louis Lefebvre), on a train with only a sleeping adult for company, welcomes his old friend Bruel (Coco Golstein) as they prepare to return to the boredom of boarding school. The journey is filled with a sense of freedom, curtailed when they arrive at the station, to be confronted by an aloof prefect, played by an adult.

In the battle to control the boys, the prefect is revealed as a spy who steals their things. The housemaster

(Delphin), a tiny, ridiculous-looking man with a bushy beard, is also pitted against them. On the boys' side is the young teacher Huguet (Jean Dasté), who indulges his charges with impersonations of Charlie Chaplin and plays soccer with them. In one especially odd

The boys' revolution against the school's stuffed-shirt authorities takes the form of an anarchic pillow fight—for Vigo, the essence of the spirit of childhood.

sequence, he takes them all with him as he follows a young woman who has caught his eye.

The boys themselves are all serial offenders who seem to spend every Sunday in detention (hence the “zero marks for conduct” implied by the movie's title). Throughout the movie, they plot their revenge, but when it comes, the revolution starts not with a grand dramatic gesture but with a long pillow fight. Taking to the school's rooftop, they hurl objects down at the school board, a row of mannequins lined up for the annual “commemoration day” celebration. The joy of Vigo's movie is that the boys don't really try to beat the system—they want to rise above it, as gallant rebels driven by the irrepressible spirit of childhood.

Vigo did not live to see his movie achieve recognition, but his legacy went on to inform the works of directors including François Truffaut and Lindsay Anderson. ■

Jean Vigo Director

Jean Vigo was born in 1905, the son of an anarchist. His father spent most of his life on the run and was murdered in prison when Jean was 12, but he cast a long shadow over the director's short but influential career. After a series of shorts, Vigo made his lone feature, *L'Atalante*, in 1934. Although initially cut to ribbons by distributors, the movie's poetry found favor in the 1940s, going

on to inspire the founders of the French New Wave. An ill man throughout his life, Vigo died of tuberculosis at just 29. As his work gained fame in France, the Prix Jean Vigo was set up in 1951 for first-time directors.

Key movies

1930 *À propos de Nice*
1933 *Zéro de Conduite*
1934 *L'Atalante*